Funeral Parlor

By Christopher Durang

A funeral parlor. Quiet setting. Hushed atmosphere. Susan, the mourning widow, is sedate, proper and formal. A few people are in line, offering their condolences, shaking her hand. She acknowledges them with a little nod and little smile, and a whispered "Thank you." As the scene begins, at the end of the line to see Susan is a man named Marcus. Marcus reaches Susan. He is sincere and genuine, it's just that he's, well, odd.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Funerals are supposed to be quiet.*
ACTOR 1: *Brief.*
ACTOR 1: *Nod solemnly –*
ACTOR 1: *Susan is trying to grieve her husband with dignity.*
ACTOR 2: *Minimal conversation.*
ACTOR 2: *Unfortunately . . .*
(beat)
ACTOR 1: *Funeral Parlor*

ACTOR 2: *Respectful.*
ACTOR 2: *You say you're sorry –*
TOGETHER: *And leave.*

ACTOR 1: *Maximum composure.*
TOGETHER: *Marcus has arrived.*

ACTOR 2: *by Christopher Durang*

MARCUS: **(Pgs 39-52)** Susan, I'm so sorry. My deepest condolences.

SUSAN: Yes, thank you . . . ?? *(She doesn't know who Marcus is)*

MARCUS: Marcus.

SUSAN: *(Still doesn't know him, but is gracious)* Yes, Marcus. Thank you for coming.

MARCUS: We'll all miss him terribly.

SUSAN: Yes, It's a great loss.

MARCUS: We'll all miss him.

SUSAN: Yes.

MARCUS: You must feel terrible.

SUSAN: Well . . . I don't feel good. It was a terrible shock.

MARCUS: Death is always a shock. You're sitting home doing nothing, and then suddenly death goes "Boo!", and somebody falls down dead.

SUSAN: Yes. *(Looks around, hopes someone else will come over)*

MARCUS: What were his last words? Were they "Boo"?

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SUSAN: What? "Boo"? No. He didn't really have any last words.

MARCUS: Did he make any last noises?

SUSAN: Noises? What?

MARCUS: Guttural sorts of noises? Or high pitched shrieking ones? *(Makes high-pitched sounds)* Eeeeeeeeek! Eeeeeeek! Awooooooga! Awooooooga!

SUSAN: Just noises, I don't know. They were lower than that. Don't do that anymore.

MARCUS: *(Sympathetically)* Oh, Susan, you poor, poor thing. *(Turns to someone who's gotten in line behind him)* I wouldn't wait if I were you, I'm going to be a while. *(The person in line looks surprised but goes away; Susan looks alarmed).* All alone in the house now. Alone in the kitchen. Alone in the dining room. Alone in the living room – living room, that's a mocking phrase now, isn't it? Alone, alone, alone. All alone. Alone, alone, alone.

SUSAN: Please don't go on.

MARCUS: Yes, but you have to mourn, Susan, to mourn. I always thought the Irish were right to do all that keening. Do you want to keen, Susan?

SUSAN: Not really. Thank you anyway.

MARCUS: How about singing a Negro spiritual?

SUSAN: I don't think so. *(Looks madly for people)*

MARCUS: *(Sings)* Swing low, sweet chariot, Comin' for to carry me home . . .

SUSAN: Thank you for coming.

MARCUS: Don't you want to sing?

SUSAN: I don't want to keen or sing. I'm an Episcopalian. I'll cry quietly in my room later this evening. Now I must attend to the other mourners.

MARCUS: Susan, you're avoiding the sadness, I can't let you do that.

SUSAN: Please, please let me do that. It's been a terrible day. I have to bury my husband.

MARCUS: Is he in the casket? It's a closed casket, he's not actually in some other room, propped up in some stuffed chair or other, waiting there to startle someone, is he?

SUSAN: Certainly not. Thank you so much for coming.

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MARCUS: That would give someone quite a fright. They'd be standing by this chair making conversation and then realize they were talking to him, only he was stark, stone dead! Ahahahahahahaha, that would be a good one!

SUSAN: Yes, very good. *(Calls)* Oh, David! *(No luck)*

MARCUS: I'm going to miss him too, you know.

SUSAN: Ah, how nice. Or rather, how sad. Well, time heals everything.

MARCUS: You're not the only one with sorrow written on your forehead.

SUSAN: What?

MARCUS: I should say not. *(Shows his forehead, previously covered with his bangs; it has "sorrow" written on it)* Magic marker. Doesn't wash off. We're going to miss him on the commuter train. We used to exchange morning pleasantries. "Nice morning," or "Cold enough for you?" or "The train seems to be on time today for a change."

SUSAN: I see. Excuse me. I think the mortician is signaling me.

MARCUS: You know, your husband was the only person on that whole damn train who was even willing to speak to me.

SUSAN: *(Very much at a loss)* How interesting.

MARCUS: The other people would get panic in their eyes if I even started to walk in their direction, and they'd move away, or pretend to sleeping. But they didn't fool me, I'm no dope. *You can't sleep standing up!*

SUSAN: *(Trying to make small talk.)* Well, if you're tired enough maybe you can.

MARCUS: Your husband, though, was always very friendly to me. Not like my father. Nowadays my father won't even return my phone calls, I went to a séance and everything

SUSAN: What?

MARCUS: Well, he's dead, but I have this medium friend who gave me this special 800 number that lets you call the dead. Maybe you'd like the number to try to reach your husband on the other side.

SUSAN: I don't think so. Well, que sera, sera. Ah me. La dee dah. Well, thank you so much for coming.

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MARCUS: *(Warmly)* Well, you're welcome. I just feel so terrible about your husband being gone, and I don't know what I'm going to do on the train in the morning.

SUSAN: Yes. Well – why don't you read a book?

MARCUS: That's an idea. Do you have any suggestions?

SUSAN: Oh my, I don't know. *The Thorn Birds, Great Expectations*. Any book, I don't care.

MARCUS: My favorite book is *Babar the Elephant.*

SUSAN: Yes, that is excellent.

MARCUS: Have you read it?

SUSAN: No, but I hear wonderful things. Ah me. My., My. Well, thank you for coming. Good-bye.

MARCUS: *(Surprised)* Are you leaving?

SUSAN: *(Losing her temper)* No, I'm not leaving. I want *you* to leave. You're making me hysterical. Can't you take a hint. When I say "Thank you for coming," that's code for "Go away now." Don't you understand that?

MARCUS: *(Terribly abashed, a bit hurt)* Oh. I'm sorry. I thought it just meant "Thank you for coming." I'm sorry. I didn't realize I . . . Is there anything else you've said in code I haven't understood?

SUSAN: No. Nothing. I don't think so.

MARCUS: *(Still a little thrown)* Oh good. *(He looks very abashed and embarrassed.)*

SUSAN: It's . . . just . . . well . . . *(Feeling badly for him.)* Oh dear, now I feel terribly guilty about having expressed my emotions.

MARCUS: *(Friendly again, thinking of her)* Oh don't feel guilty about expressing emotions. That's a *good* thing to do. You've had a terrible loss.

SUSAN: *(Somewhat seriously, realizing)* Yes, I have.

MARCUS: Are you sure you don't want to keen yet? I'm not Irish, but I think it's a very appropriate thing to do at a wake.

SUSAN: Oh I don't know. Maybe another time.

MARCUS: This would be the most likely time.

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SUSAN: Well, I don't know. *(A little interested)* What does keening sound like exactly?

MARCUS: Oh, it's real interesting. It's sort of like this. *(Marcus makes an enormously strange, low, sustained moan-whine that goes up and down the scale. The rest of the people present come to a dead halt and stare.)*

SUSAN: *(To crowd; slightly annoyed.)* Please stop staring. Go back to your conversational buzz. *(The crowd goes back to its hum)*

MARCUS: Did I do something wrong again?

SUSAN: Well, it was a very startling sound.

MARCUS: It's just like crying, but more dramatic. I love to cry. You loved your husband, didn't you?

SUSAN: *(Genuine)* Yes.

MARCUS: Well, then, don't you want to keen just a little?

SUSAN: Well, I see your point a little but . . . I don't know that I really could.

MARCUS: You could do it softer than I did.

SUSAN: I don't think so

MARCUS: Oh please, I'm sure it would make you feel better.

SUSAN: *(Wanting to feel better)* Would it? *(Starts to, but freezes)* This is difficult to do in public. Couldn't I call you later this evening, and do it on the phone?

MARCUS: No, it's much more healing to keen at the funeral. You shouldn't do it on the phone.

SUSAN: Oh, I don't know.

MARCUS: Come on. It'll help.

SUSAN: *(Hesitates, but then)* Ooooooo *(It's very soft Sounds like a ghost sound, or a person imitating the wind)*

MARCUS: That's good

SUSAN: Ooooooooo.

MARCUS: That's good AAAAAAOOOOOOWWWWWWOOOOOOOO!!!! *(Susan looks aghast for a moment. The crowd stops and stares again. Momentary silence. After a beat, Susan gives in to some odd combination of grief and having fun, and makes extremely loud keening sound simultaneously with Marcus)*

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BOTH: AAAAAAAAAOOOOOOOOOOOOWWWWWWWWWOOOOOOOOOOO!!!! *(From out of these very satisfying, if shocking noises, Susan starts to cry loudly and uninhibitedly. Marcus pats her on the back in a comforting manner, looking out at the crowd a bit proudly as if to say "See what I did?" Susan's crying subsides, and her breathing returns more to normal)*

MARCUS: There, that's better.

SUSAN: *(Drying her yes)* Thank you so much for coming. *(Just as Marcus begins to wonder)* No, no, not code. Thank you. I feel much better.

MARCUS: Oh good. Well, you're welcome. *(Marcus and Susan shake hands warmly. Marcus smiles at her, moves aside, as other mourners come over to speak to Susan. Quick fade. End).*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
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You can watch Robin Williams and Carol Burnett perform this selection at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jfDyTUiL8xs - There's a partial 2nd version with lots of Robin Williams "ad-libbing" that is also funny, but is not in the original script.

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